

the type of life you want. That gets you talking to your spouse and friends and imagining the new life. When retirement day comes, you're ready.

Perhaps the best shock absorber is to keep from having to handle too much change at one time. Sometimes the timing of life's change is outside our control. We must accept the death of a loved one when it happens, for example, rather than when it might be convenient for us. We must accept a tax increase when Congress dictates, rather than when we're flush. Most of us must move when we retire, rather than wait a few years.

But we *can* control a great deal of change in our lives. The example is a coed who turns 22, gets married, moves to a new city, buys a house, and starts her first job, all in June of the year she graduates from college. With that much change it's not a question of whether she'll get sick but when. Neither the career nor the marriage has much of a chance. She would be better off to graduate and move, take the summer off, and then start the new job. The marriage and house purchase can wait until she feels settled at work.

Remember Lyle, my friend who got fired a few years before he was going to retire? I suggested that getting fired was a lousy way to retire. Dr. Holmes's point scale explains why. Getting fired is 47 points and retiring is 45. Do them both at the same time and you're up to 92. Move out of the old neighborhood, start living with less, and begin to travel, and that 92 jumps to 200 or so. Toss in some external change beyond your control—the death of a parent, for example, or a lawsuit—and you're approaching the deadly 300 number. Remember, the closer you get to 300, the more likely you are to become seriously ill.

When you retire you should work solely on retiring. If you can possibly help it, avoid adding other change to your life. Chapter 4, for example, tells how to avoid writing a big check to the IRS when you sell your home. That kind of trauma can really sock you when your life is already full of